



Mostly cloudy 40/30 • Tomorrow: Mostly cloudy 46/27 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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MARVIN JOSEPH/THE WASHINGTON POST

At a hearing Thursday, Kristi L. Noem told one House Democrat, “I will consider your asking me to resign as an endorsement of my work.”

Democrats urge Noem to resign at fiery hearing

SESSION TURNS INTO REFERENDUM ON JOB

GOP praises DHS secretary’s anti-immigration efforts

BY MARIANNE LEVINE

Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem faced a combative congressional hearing Thursday, as Democratic lawmakers repeatedly demanded that she resign, accusing her of lying and violating the law as she helps lead the Trump administration’s mass deportation agenda.

Republicans, by contrast, heaped praise on Noem for reducing illegal immigration and, in their view, improving public safety, as the hearing broke sharply along party lines and illustrated the nation’s bitter partisan divide.

Democrats pressed her to explain why scores of U.S. citizens have been detained during immigration enforcement operations and highlighted cases of immigrants who have lived in the United States for decades being deported — including some who served in the U.S. military. Protesters interrupted Noem’s opening remarks, with one shouting, “Get ICE off our streets, stop terrorizing our communities” — a reference to Immigration and Customs Enforcement — before being escorted out of the hearing room.

“Rather than you sitting here and wasting your time and ours with more corruption, lies and lawlessness, I call on you to resign,” Rep. Bennie G. Thompson (Mississippi), the House Homeland Security Committee’s ranking Democrat, told Noem in his opening remarks. “Do a real service to your country and just re-

sign — that is, unless President Trump fires you first.”

The appearance marked Noem’s second before the committee, and the hearing, nominally focused on national security threats, quickly veered into a referendum on her leadership amid mounting public scrutiny, and waning support, for the Department of Homeland Security’s hard-line immigration enforcement tactics.

Democrats were further angered after Noem left the hearing early to oversee a meeting of the Federal Emergency Management Agency, which falls under DHS. However, that meeting was postponed. A DHS spokesperson said Noem did not learn of the meeting’s cancellation until after she had left.

Rep. Michael McCaul (R-Texas) defended Noem, calling the border more secure than at any other time in his more than two decades in Congress. He said the hearing reminded him of the Charles Dickens novel “A Tale of Two Cities.”

“The Dems see it as the worst of times, but I see it really as the best of times,” McCaul said.

Noem’s testimony came amid media reports that Trump is considering replacing her as DHS chief because of mounting dissatisfaction at the White House over the pace of building out detention centers. Trump sought to tamp down that speculation this week, pronouncing himself “so happy” with Noem and calling her

SEE HEARING ON A8

Two Trump-backed peace deals appear to unravel

BY TOBI RAJI

Two peace agreements that President Donald Trump took credit for brokering are under severe strain. Violent clashes have intensified on the Thailand-Cambodia border and between the Democratic Republic of Congo and the Rwanda-backed M23 militia.

On Monday, less than two months after Trump signed a peace agreement to resolve a border dispute between Cambodia and Thailand, the Thai air force

Conflicts that president took credit for resolving persist in Asia, Africa

carried out airstrikes on its neighbor, renewing what has become the worst spate of violence between the two countries in decades. Both sides blamed the other for instigating the attack and for violating the terms of the peace deal. Both also claimed to

be acting in self-defense.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio urged Thailand and Cambodia in a post on X on Tuesday to “immediately cease hostilities, protect civilians, and return to the de-escalatory measures outlined in the Kuala Lumpur Peace Accords.”

In the Democratic Republic of Congo, President Félix Tshisekedi on Monday accused Rwanda of violating the terms of a U.S.-brokered peace agreement, signed last week during a ceremony at the newly renamed Donald J. Trump Institute of Peace in Wash-

ington.

Last week’s signing ceremony finalized a deal brokered in June that was supposed to end the decades-long conflict between the Central African countries. But the fighting has continued, prompting roughly 200,000 people to flee their homes in eastern Congo, Reuters reported. By Wednesday, the M23 rebel group had entered Uvira, a town near Burundi, Congolese Information Minister Patrick Muyaya told The Washington Post. The United Nations says

SEE TRUMP ON A13

Measure to extend ACA subsidies fails in Senate

Blockage of Democratic bill paves way for their end-of-year expiration

BY THEODORIC MEYER, PAIGE WINFIELD CUNNINGHAM, RILEY BEGGIN AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

The Senate blocked a bill Thursday to extend Affordable Care Act health insurance subsidies, all but ensuring they will expire at the end of the year.

The vote was the culmination of Democrats’ months-long push to extend the subsidies and prevent premiums from rising for

millions of Americans — a campaign that helped trigger the longest federal government shutdown in history. Republicans promised to hold the vote as part of a deal to end the shutdown.

Four Republicans — Sens. Susan Collins (Maine), Dan Sullivan (Alaska), Josh Hawley (Missouri) and Lisa Murkowski (Alaska) — voted for the Democratic bill, which needed 60 votes to advance. It got 51, with 48 senators voting against.

The Senate also blocked a Republican health care bill that Sens. Bill Cassidy (Louisiana) and Mike Crapo (Idaho) drafted as an alternative to the Democratic one. That bill, which also needed 60 votes to advance, failed 51-48,

SEE SUBSIDIES ON A8

Backlash brews as billionaires amass political power in U.S.

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

BROOKVILLE, INDIANA — Christina Persson, a 55-year-old English teacher in this small town of just over 2,600 people, is fed up with billionaires.

In May, during the debate over President Donald Trump’s One Big Beautiful Bill, she spearheaded a move to erect a billboard reading, “Tax breaks for billionaires. CUTS for everyone else.”

Two months later, she set up shop at the county fair and sold “Eat the Rich” ice cream sand-

wiches stamped with the faces of some of the wealthiest Americans, including Elon Musk. She charged “\$5 or best offer”; all 60 sandwiches were snapped up.

A single mother with a son in college, Persson, who owns a small farm and teaches at a local college, said she makes less than \$30,000 a year and faces more than \$190,000 in student loan payments. “I’m not even middle class, really,” said Persson, who began volunteering part-time as chair of the county Democrats

SEE BILLIONAIRES ON A7



FILIFE AMORIM/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

The Rev. Guilherme Peixoto performs during a fair in Coimbra, Portugal, on July 4.

The word of God — through techno

With pope’s blessing, a Portuguese priest connects by dropping beats

BY KIM BELLWARE

The Rev. Guilherme Peixoto was sitting down for dinner the night before a high-profile DJ gig in Slovakia — a combination youth festival and birthday celebration for the archbishop of Kosice — when the church’s production team began to buzz with excitement.

They had a new opening act: Pope Leo XIV.

Peixoto, a 51-year-old priest and DJ based in Braga, Portugal, scrambled to adjust. For almost two weeks before the November event, he had pored over melodic techno beats by Slovakian music producers and selected popular hymns in Polish and Slovak. Now he had to incorporate a special video message from the Holy Father that the Vatican had sent to surprise the archbishop.

“I said, ‘Yes, okay, I need to work this [in] for tomorrow,’” Peixoto recalled in a Zoom interview last week.

With members of his production team, Peixoto worked through the night, adding tracks of synthesizers to the pope’s address, mixing and mastering, and waking again at 3 a.m. to finish.

That evening, fog wafted around the dramatically lit St. Elizabeth’s Cathedral in Kosice as Pope Leo’s message played on a video screen to swirling synthesizers. As the pope’s “Amen” echoed over the crowd, lights flashed and the music built.

Then Peixoto dropped the beat.

Video of the set’s opening went viral, drawing more than 10 million views on Instagram alone.

SEE POPE ON A13

Abrego is released by order of judge

Ruling: Government can’t indefinitely detain Salvadoran immigrant

BY MARIA SACCHETTI, JEREMY ROEBUCK AND TEO ARMUS

Kilmar Abrego García was released from U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement custody Thursday after a federal judge ruled his continued detention was unlawful.

U.S. District Judge Paula Xinis ordered officials to release the 30-year-old undocumented immigrant and longtime Maryland resident in part to ensure that he has a fair immigration process. She found that Justice Department attorneys and an ICE witness had “misled” the court at a hearing last month when they said they had to deport Abrego to the African nation of Liberia because Costa Rica, in Central America, had reneged on a deal to offer him refuge.

But the judge, citing reporting by The Washington Post and other media outlets, noted that Costa Rica had “never wavered” in its commitment to accept Abrego. He was released from a Pennsylvania

SEE ABREGO ON A9

IN THE NEWS

Faith-based teaching A new public school in Colorado with a “Christian foundation” is the latest to test the legal limits of funding. A4

Hundreds quarantined A measles outbreak in South Carolina has accelerated, with cases spiking in the wake of Thanksgiving travel and a lack of vaccinations. A9

THE NATION A wildlife group sued over plans to put a photo of Trump on the 2026 national parks pass. A2
The president’s Venezuela threats echo CIA-backed regime change in Latin America. A12

THE WORLD Russia banned the popular Roblox gaming site, sparking backlash from youths. A14
The U.S. signaled a campaign to seize more oil tankers in bid to oust Venezuela’s leader. A12

THE ECONOMY The website for Trump’s \$1 million “gold card” visa program was unveiled amid questions about its viability and legality. A15
The family of a slain 83-year-old woman filed a lawsuit claiming that ChatGPT bears responsibility. A15

STYLE Brian Glenn, the White House reporter dating Marjorie Taylor Greene, is in a tricky position. B1

SPORTS Philip Rivers, the Colts’ new (old, very old) quarterback has come out of retirement with hopes of saving the season for Indianapolis. B7

THE REGION After renovations, the living quarters of George Washington’s Mount Vernon home are open to the public after nearly two years. B13
With more than 5,000 couples ready and willing, D.C. aims to set the world record for a kiss under the mistletoe. B13

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